Hydraphobia

By Gary R. McClain

INTRODUCTION

The one feeling that I have heard from practically everyone who is touched by HIV/AIDS is fear. Fear is one of the primary feelings that gets in the way of hope. And we need hope to be fully alive with HIV/AIDS. So how can we deal with fear? Faith is one powerful answer. If you love someone living with HIV or AIDS, "Fear not; only believe." Believe that you can translate your fear into loving acts of kindness. As you focus on loving your friend or family member with HIV/AIDS, the fear will fall away. Hydraphobia by Gary R. McClain brings to life this fear of the Hydra: A Greek root meaning a multifarious evil, or an evil having many sources; not to be overcome by a single effort.

I remember spending the week after our first date waiting for the phone to ring, or at least for it to ring with Alby on the other end. I had asked him out, after all, so now it was his turn. But the pain ... I thought about him while I was getting ready in the mornings and on the subway ride to school. I thought about him when I was sitting in my office, waiting for the next student to come in.

I was hooked on him.

That evening, exactly six days after our first date, the phone rang. You're a love-stricken school child and you know that leads to tears and drama, I said to myself during those two seconds that occurred between picking up the phone, taking a deep breath, and uttering a hello that was deepened by an exhale of breath.

"Mike?"

"Who else would be here?" I answered, recognizing his voice.

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"It's Alby. And what do you mean who else? A handsome guy like you must have elses crawling out of the woodwork."

"The super sprayed last week."

It must have been obvious to him that I was excited. I again reminded myself that I was planning to be cool, but it was way beyond too late at this point. Yes, I was hooked. We made some small talk about how the week had gone. His ad agency was waiting for a decision on their new business presentation, he told me, and I told him the story of my successful Freud lecture that day.

"I'd love to see you teach, really watch you in action," he said. "You must be a killer."

"Well, I don't know. Usually I hope I can make it through a lecture without a few nod-offs."

"You're modest. I like that in a man."

We talked about getting together for dinner sometime soon. We volleyed some more conversation around. Yeah, we'll do that soon. Yeah, we have to get together. Yeah, right.

"How about Saturday?"

That Saturday evening, after we had spent the day talking and walking and, finally grabbing some dinner, we ended up standing in front the window in my apartment overlooking the rooftops. Alby stood behind me.

"If I were an artist, I'd want to paint this scene," he said.

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"Why?"

"I don't know. The buildings just seem to go on forever. It's like being in a forest or a canyon or something. A concrete valley." His voice was soft, almost sad, and I turned around to face him. He stepped back.

"What is it?" I asked.

"I know I've been holding back from you, making you do all the work. I'm not trying to be coy or anything. But I'm not ready for anything else yet.

Visions of other boyfriends, or a reconciliation with his latest ex, flashed through my mind, and I reminded myself that I had to be careful here. "Is your white knight coming back on the scene?"

"No, it's not that. We just need to talk."

"Why do I feel like I'm going to hate this?" I asked. "Can't it wait?"

Alby placed his hands lightly on my shoulders. I smiled and tried to think of something funny to say, but I couldn't.

"Let's get this over with," I said.

"I haven't always been perfect. In fact I never was." He hesitated again, sought my eyes out with his, and then leaned his face toward mine. "Mike, I'm HIV positive."

I felt my breath catch. No thoughts, images, fears, nothing. I was in the middle of an inhale, and it just caught in my throat as I felt my blood rushing toward my feet. I reached up and wrapped my arms around his waist and pulled him closer to

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me. I held him, tightly, to reassure him, or to reassure myself. This is no big deal, I kept repeating to myself. Nothing is proven. This means nothing. I said this over and over, in my mind, while I held on to him.

"It's not a problem for me," I said finally. "It's not a problem."

"I've been positive for a long time," he said. "Only my sister knows, and now you."

I tightened my grip. "I'm glad you told me.

I told myself that I felt relieved. It was out in the open. So what? He looked perfectly healthy. It seemed like a less insurmountable obstacle than if had told me he had another lover on the scene. And there was that other feeling, the one that I kept trying to push off, that vague sense of another kind of relief, maybe you could call it some kind of perverse feeling of security. He must need me. Yes, I would be there. Love would save the day. Or at least it would save us.

"We can pop in a video if you want," I said. "I've got the silent version of Metropolis. Have you seen it? It's really great."

"Do you want to talk anymore?" he asked.

"About what?"

"There are other things you should know."

Before he could say anything else, I went to my bedroom closet to dig out the video. There was nothing more to say, I knew more than I wanted to. How would talking, or even thinking about it, accomplish anything? Maybe if we ignored it, the whole thing would fade away.

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The candles flickered as a breeze came in through the window, throwing a flash of light in his eyes. They were opened wide, searching for something in mine. Reassurance, maybe, or the real truth. And sad. He reached over and took my hand.

"Are you sure you really want to do this?" he asked.

"Absolutely sure, I've never been surer."

"More sure," he corrected me.

"That too."

He squeezed my hand. "We have to be careful. You know that."

I laughed, then took his hand. "I'm ready already."

I was still on that euphoria when I went in to school Monday morning, But by the time I finally had a chance to settle into my office, the euphoria was giving way to a free-floating angst. I sat at my desk and thumbed through the notes for the day's lecture. I turned the pages, reading but not understanding, re-reading and still not able to concentrate. Finally, I got up from my desk, locked my door, turned out the lights, and settled in to let the angst flow over me for awhile.

First, I saw Alby, sitting across from me at dinner. We were looking at each other and talking in hushed, desperate voices. Decisions to be made. Or walking down the street laughing together like any other couple, but clutching each other's hands tightly as if a gale wind might blow through at any moment. Then he was in the hospital; I was holding his hand and trying to smile at him. "Hi buddy," I would say. "How are you, buddy?" Wringing my hands.

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I went back through every relationship I had ever been in, the good times, bad times, the gradual growing apart in some, the emotionally wrenching arguments, and discoveries of infidelities in others. I thought about how each relationship had been tenuous, uncertain, in its own way. Even in the best of physical health, no promises that the next week, month, the next day, it would be as good as it was right at that moment. Never a guarantee that there would be a next day.

This is no different, I told myself. A car might hit him tomorrow, and the HIV status won't mean a damned thing. One might hit me too. Either way, life is uncertain, I couldn't promise him anything more than he could promise me.

Was I already in too deep? Was I about to be pulled under by a drowning man? It was early on in the relationship. I had time to get out, somewhat unscathed. I could let him down easy, or just start pulling away. The door was open.

Diiiiiiive.....

I wanted him to go away. I wanted to run. I wanted to be with him no matter what. I wanted him to run. I wanted to pretend I was in the middle of a bad video and hit rewind. But I also wanted Alby.

Dammit. It was not supposed to be this way.

My eyes wandered toward a poster that hung over my desk of a bright turquoise ocean and a blue sky, a white boat with red sails. It was a joke on myself, in a way. I've been terrified of water since I was a third grader and my mother sent me to swimming lessons. The instructor, a high school jock, spent most of each class hitting on the female lifeguard. She was the one who busted me, told him I was

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cheating by wading across the pool and not kicking. He jumped in -- the only time he ever got wet -- and held my head underwater until I took big swallows of chlorine. He gave me a few seconds to swallow and gasp, then held me under again.

Aversion therapy, the behaviorists would call this poster. Torture yourself with something you're afraid of and maybe it will go away.

Alby loved water and had taken a few sailboat lessons in college. As I stared at the sailboat, I imagined the two of us standing with the boat, in shallow water, and slowly pushing it away from the shore. First the water was at my ankles, then my knees, then my waist.

"Is there enough breeze yet?" I asked Alby.

"Not yet," he said.

We went out further. The water was higher than my waist, then up to my armpits. I could feel myself beginning to hyperventilate.

"Jump in," Alby said. "Let's go."

"I can't," I replied. "I'm scared of the water."

"Then I'll have to go alone. Give me a push."

"No. Not yet. Give me some time."

I continued to stare at the poster as the hours passed. In the late afternoon, as the sun began to fade, the ocean started to look dark, like a storm was moving in. The sailboat faded, became a shadow.

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I slipped away into that world of half-awake-half-asleep that, if you play it right, can keep you from away from reality but also away from dreaming. But then I must have dreamed about something, because I jerked into a sitting position, feeling as if I was suffocating. I gasped for air.

When I caught my breath, I found myself in the dark.

The building was silent, probably locked from outside. I could leave now and not have to worry about being accosted in the hallway. I stood up. There was just enough light coming through the frosted glass window to allow me to fumble around for my backpack and keys. I felt for the door handle, letting my hand slide past the wall switch for the ceiling light.

It was really darkness that I wanted. Just enough light to see my way out without having to look at any of the details.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

Dramatic Interp – Hawaii State Qualifier

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